Reading · L8 · Reading

Short story: “Not yet”

A Vachuo original story · 4 pages

The rains were meant to come in March. Everyone in Wanjiru’s village said so, the way people say the sun will rise. Her grandmother said so too, but she said it more quietly each week.

On Saturday morning Wanjiru walked to the shamba before breakfast. The soil along the path had split into pieces like a broken plate. She pressed one with her toe and it crumbled into dust. Above her, the sky was the pale, washed blue of an old school uniform. Not a single cloud.

Back at the house, Grandmother had laid the seed bag on the table. Beans from last year, dried and sorted, enough for the whole field. Wanjiru looked at the bag, and then at the sky through the doorway, and then at her grandmother’s hands, which were very still.

“Not yet,” said Grandmother.

Wanjiru folded the top of the seed bag twice, the way she had been shown, and carried it to the shelf above the water jars. She pushed it right to the back, behind the tin of matches.

In the afternoon her cousin Otieno came over with a football. “Are you planting this weekend?” he asked. Wanjiru shrugged. “The beans are on the shelf.”

Otieno looked at the shelf, and then at the cracked yard, and didn’t ask again. They played until the dust got into their throats and they had to stop and drink.

That night Wanjiru lay awake listening. Once she thought she heard rain, a soft drumming on the iron roof, and sat up. It was only Grandmother, tapping her fingers on the table in the dark.

In the morning the sky was the same. Grandmother made tea without sugar. “We will wait,” she said. “The soil remembers when we are patient.”

Wanjiru didn’t answer. She went outside and looked at the horizon for a long time, the way her grandmother did, as if looking hard enough could bring the clouds closer.

A week later, on a Tuesday, the wind changed. It came from the east, cool and heavy, and smelled of something Wanjiru hadn’t smelled in months. She ran inside. Grandmother was already standing at the shelf, reaching for the seed bag.

Think about: the story never says “there was a drought” or “Grandmother was worried”. How do you know?

Clue hunt

Clue in the text	What I know	So I think...
The soil had split into pieces		
Grandmother's hands were very still		
Pushed it right to the back		
Tea without sugar		
The wind... smelled of something		

1. Finish the sentence: Because the text says _____, I think _____.

2. Why do you think Otieno "didn't ask again"?

3. What do you think happens next? Point to a clue.